OTHER SOLDIERS OF NAPOLEON'S ARMY

In forming his Grande Armée, Napoleon built on the inheritance of the French Revolution, with its emphasis on the "citizen-soldier", but created a force motivated by duty, honour, and the lust for glory, rather than by revolutionary enthusiasm. Around 1.6 million men of French birth and over 700,000 born in Italy, Poland, and other parts of Europe eventually served in the ranks of Napoleon's army. More than a million are reckoned to have died, many in combat but far more of hardship or disease, expiring in military hospitals, foreign prisons, or simply by the roadside. Yet, inspired by devotion to their great military leader, Napoleon's soldiers showed consistent courage, discipline, and endurance, even in the face of steadily worsening odds after the disastrous Russian campaign of 1812.

THE INFANTRY

In 1804 the infantry of Napoleon's Grande Armée numbered some 350,000 men, divided into line infantry and light infantry regiments. At that early stage in the Napoleonic adventure the foot soldiers were superbly trained and capable of executing rapid and precise manoeuvres on the battlefield. The constant pressure of war and the attrition of veterans ensured that the Emperor's troops would never attain the same quality again. From 1805 onward, fresh recruits received only the most basic training, being expected to learn soldiering from more experienced colleagues.

The average infantryman was a conscript, and in many cases not a willing one. The annual call-up was the occasion of widespread draft evasion. The better-off paid substitutes; others simply hid or deserted after enrolment. Yet the morale of the infantry regiments were generally high. The army very quickly became the conscript's home, group solidarity ensuring low desertion rates once men were integrated in their regiments.

Napoleon's style of warfare, involving forced marches punctuated by pitched battles, placed daunting demands upon the infantry. They were expected to march 25km (15 miles) a day for weeks on end. Once outside French territory they supplied themselves by pillaging the area through which they marched. When the population was actively hostile and the countryside poor, as in Russia and Spain, this was a hazardous mode of operation. Wear and tear left the foot soldiers a ragged body of men as a campaign went on.

On the battlefield, the infantry were usually expected to take the offensive. Preceded by a swarm of skirmishers – the "voltigeurs" – massed infantry columns marched, with bayonets fixed, into the enemy musket volleys, seeking to engage at close quarters or make the enemy break and flee. Casualties were expected to be heavy; soldiers were forbidden to stop to help wounded comrades. Even after the destruction of a generation of soldiers in the Russian campaign of 1812, the ever more inexperienced infantry never ceased to fight with enthusiasm and aggression.



Infantry uniform and weapons
Like the redcoats, French infantry fought chiefly with musket and bayonet. Unlike their British counterparts, most French infantrymen also carried a sword.



Siege of Ratisbon
French troops use scaling ladders in the siege of Ratisbon (Regensburg) during Napoleon's campaign against Austria in 1809.